Beijing helps extricate Iran from looming war with the United States

Twice in the last 28 years, China has helped the Islamic Republic of Iran extricate itself from war or imminent war. One was in 1988 at the end of the eight-year-long Iran–Iraq war when China acted as Iran's spokesperson in the Security Council to secure language and terms favourable to Tehran in a Security Council resolution ending the fighting.[5] The second episode was in 2013–2015, when Iran confronted armed attack by Israel and the United States, and China played a positive and constructive role in bringing the P5+1 and Iran to agreement on terms for suspension of Iran's nuclear weapons programme.[6] The second episode is relevant to this investigation because Beijing used China's 2013–15 mediation effort as leverage for a proposal to Iran of substantially expanded China–Iran cooperation.

By 2013, due to multiple, direct, and very frank communications from Israel, Beijing had concluded that, unless Iran came to terms with the United States over the terms of is nuclear weapons effort, the Persian Gulf was heading for another war. That war would injure a number of Chinese interests. It would: disrupt China's oil supply, injure China's exports to the region, thwart Beijing's BRI plans for the region, make investment difficult, and throw the world economy back into recession. A war between Iran and the United States could also leave Iran a shambles, perhaps like Iraq after the 1991 and 2003 wars, further strengthening US dominance in the Gulf. Beijing conveyed this sincere and frank advice to Tehran. China advised Tehran to do what was necessary to address the concerns of the international community over Iran's nuclear programmes. China played a significant role in inducing Tehran to come to terms with the July 2015 agreement.